



THE CAMPAIGN IS A CRUSHING BLOW AFTER THE HIGH OF THE FOURTH-PLACE FINISH AT TOKYO OLYMPICS AND LEAVES PLENTY OF QUESTIONS TO BE ANSWERED

B opener. The players started nervously, made basic errors and conceded an early goal. Despite earning seven penalty corners, India could not find the equaliser.

From there on, Schopman's team had to treat almost every match as a virtual final and it played like that.

In a must-win second Group B match against New Zealand, India took the lead inside 40 seconds with Salima Tete setting up the goal for fellow local player Sangita Kumari. While the Black Sticks did level the score, India kept its foot on the pedal and took a 3-1 lead as the first quarter finished. The team never relinquished that advantage and brought its campaign back on track.

With USA beating New Zealand 1-0 to clinch the top spot in Group B, India only needed a draw against Italy to finish second and progress to the semifinals. Just like the previous encounter, the women in blue made a blistering start as Udita converted a penalty in the opening minute. The

Painful exit: Playing the same venue where it won the Asian Champions Trophy last year and being the second-highest ranked side behind Germany were expected to give enough confidence to the Indian side to finish in the top three. However, it wasn't to be. PTI

host eventually wrapped up a convincing 5-1 win.

From Group A, Germany and Japan finished first and second, respectively, ahead of Chile and Czechia.

India had to face Germany in the semifinals with the winner confirming its berth for the Summer Games. Die Danas were the pre-match favourites but it was the host team that made the first blow in a match played in hazy conditions, with temperatures hovering from 12°-13° Celsius.

Deepika converted a penalty in

the 15th minute to put India ahead. However, lapses in concentration from the Indian defence not only allowed Charlotte Stapenhorst to equalise 12 minutes later but also give Germany the lead with three minutes remaining.

Ishika Chaudhary brought India back in the game after deflecting a rebound off India's third penalty in the 59th minute and the host team managed to take the game to a penalty shootout, giving itself another shot at victory.

Valentin Altenburg's side came back from 1-2 down to win 4-3 in sudden death in the shootout with Lisa Nottle nutmegging Savita to take Germany over the line. While not as dramatic as this, USA too had come from behind to defeat Japan 2-1 in the first semifinal.

The bronze medal match between India and Japan was also set to decide who would join China, the Asian Games gold medallist, in Paris as the only other Asian team.

The after-effects of that devastating loss to Germany was felt as India turned up in less than 24 hours for its do-or-die game against

Search for the answers: The campaign, led by captain Savita Punia (left) and Janneke Schopman (right), is a crushing blow after the high of the fourth-place finish at Tokyo Olympics three years ago and leaves plenty of questions to be answered. PTI

